MASTERING LINE GRAPHS · CHAPTER 1 CHEAT SHEET

Understanding Line Graphs

Read the graph before you write a word.

Read in this order

1. **Title:** what is measured, where and when. You will paraphrase it.
2. **Horizontal axis:** the time period.
3. **Vertical axis:** the quantity and its unit: %, thousands, litres.
4. **Legend:** what each line represents.
5. **Data points:** the values at each interval.

Five key features

1. The **overall trend** of each line
2. **Start and end points**
3. **Significant changes:** sharp rises, sudden falls
4. **Peaks and lowest points**
5. **Comparisons:** which line is highest, and where lines cross

If a detail would be true of almost any graph (it has a title and a legend), it is not a key feature.

Your job in Task 1

Select the important information, **describe** it accurately and **compare** where relevant.

Don't just list figures. The most common mistake is describing each line on its own. Say which was highest, which changed most, and how the lines relate.

Don't explain why the data changed. Reasons are not in the graph.

Describe the data, not the line

DON'T WRITE	WRITE
The line goes up.	The number of visitors rose.
The lines cross.	Online reading overtook print.
Print is above online.	Print reading was higher than online reading.
The orange line	the figure for Japan

Number, amount or percentage?

- **the number of** + countable noun: visitors, cars
- **the amount of** + uncountable noun: water, coffee
- **the percentage / proportion of** + noun, when the figures are %

Units and numbers

- Always give the unit: *from 18% to 74%*, not *from 18 to 74*.
- Axis says *(millions)*? Write **10 million**, never 10 millions.
- The noun stays plural: **2 million books**.
- For thousands, write the full number: **4,000 visitors**.

Introduction and overview

Introduction: one sentence. What, who, where, when, in your own words. Never "the graph below".

Overview: starts with *Overall,*. The main trends and the key comparison. No data figures.